

The Empower School
Health and Safety Policy



Health and Safety Policy

for

The Empower School Ltd

This Policy is available on our website.

This Policy is available on our website and is available on request. We also inform parents and carers about this policy when their children join our school.

This policy will be reviewed in full by The Empower School Ltd on an annual basis. This policy was last reviewed and agreed by the Directors of The Empower School Ltd on 20th January 2025. It is due for review on 20th January 2026.

Signature

Director

Date:

Signature

Director

Date:

The Empower School Health and Safety Policy

Policy Statement

The following is a statement of The Empower School Ltd Health & Safety Policy in accordance with Section 2 of the Health & Safety at Work etc Act 1974. We regard all health & safety legislation as the minimum standard.

It is the policy of The Empower School Ltd to, so far as is reasonably practicable, ensure the health, safety and welfare of all staff and volunteers working for the business and other persons who may be affected by our undertakings.

It is also policy to prevent damage to personal property and the environment so far as is reasonably practicable. The senior management of The Empower School Ltd looks upon the promotion of health and safety (H&S) measures as a mutual objective for themselves, staff, and volunteers. Therefore, responsibility for health and safety is shared between Directors, all employees, volunteers, contractors, and visitors. The degree of responsibility is detailed in the Health & Safety Policy.

The key to successful H&S management requires an effective policy, organisation, and arrangements, which reflect the commitment of senior management, the values of the organisation and feedback from employees. To maintain this commitment, we will continually measure, monitor, improve and revise where necessary to ensure that health and safety standards are adequately maintained.

The business will ensure a systematic approach to identifying hazards, assessing risks, determining suitable and sufficient control measures, and ensuring staff and volunteers are informed of the correct procedures needed to maintain a safe working environment. We will provide, so far as is reasonably practicable, suitable risk assessments, safety information, standard operating procedures, training, and supervision.

The Empower School Ltd will ensure continued consultation with the workforce to enable all viewpoints and recommendations to be discussed at regular intervals.

Responsibilities

Summary of Responsibilities

All Employees & Freelance Staff All employees have a legal duty to take reasonable care of their own health and safety and the health and safety of others who may be affected by their acts or omissions. Employees are expected to properly use and not interfere with anything provided to safeguard their health and safety. Employees should cooperate with their Line Managers on health and safety matters and concerns should be reported to an appropriate person. All employees are expected to read and follow the safety information relevant to their role.

Directors and Senior Leadership

Directors and Senior Management are responsible for promoting a positive health and safety culture. Directors and Senior Management should establish an effective communication and management structure. This would include ensuring that information about health and safety is accessible by all who need it. They should consider the health and safety implications of all business decisions and set targets for improvement. They should ensure that employees have the sufficient resources (including time and tools) to follow safety procedures.

Directors and Senior Management should lead by example and should be seen to promote positive messages regarding health and safety. The Directors will implement the Business's Health & Safety Policy and recommend any changes to meet new circumstances. The Empower School Ltd recognises that successful health and safety management contributes to successful business performance and will allocate adequate finances and resources to meet these needs.

Health & Safety Officer

The Health and Safety Officer should maintain the Health & Safety Management System and ensure that policy and risk assessment is fit for purpose. The Health and Safety Officer should review performance and take both proactive and reactive actions to improve safety.

Site Leads

Site Leads are responsible for the day-to-day operations of our locations. They are responsible for communicating any safety concerns to an appropriate person on behalf of the staff working at the location. Site Leads should ensure that staff working at their site are aware of safety measures and have access to PPE relevant to their jobs. Site Leads undertake formal monitoring of the sites.

First Aiders

First Aiders should provide treatment in accordance with their training and keep a record of all treatment given. They should ensure that relevant information is passed onto other staff and emergency services. They should ensure that the stock of first aid equipment is replaced.

Fire Wardens

In the case of evacuation, Fire Wardens should perform a sweep of their allocated area and encourage people to leave. They should turn off equipment, close doors and inform senior staff that the evacuation is done.

Designated Safeguarding Lead

The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL) has a number of important responsibilities to fulfil on an ongoing basis. As the lead, it is part of their duty to ensure others in the organisation understand and follow safeguarding procedures. They will also work closely with any other senior individuals to coordinate safeguarding duties. They will apply this knowledge to help implement and maintain safeguarding procedures and policies, as well as be alert to safeguarding issues on a day-to-day basis. This includes ensuring that staff have received appropriate training, that their own training is up to date, that safe recruitment practices are sufficient, and that all actions are within the best interest of safeguarding children. If the DSL identifies any concerns or another member of staff raises them, they will coordinate with the child's primary caregiver(s) if suitable and the necessary external bodies to pursue a course of action.

Contractors

Contractors have a legal duty to take reasonable care of their own health and safety and the health and safety of others who may be affected by their acts or omissions.

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Contractors have a duty to follow the health and safety arrangements laid out in risk Health and Safety Policy Page 6 of 19 assessments, whether they are provided by The Empower School Ltd or themselves. Contractors must prioritise safety above the need to complete work.

Regulatory Bodies

The Empower School Ltd adheres to all relevant guidance from regulatory bodies, such as:

- Health and Safety Executive (HSE)
- Office for Standards in Education (Ofsted)
- Reporting of Injuries, Diseases and Dangerous Occurrences Regulations (RIDDOR)
- The Royal Society for the Prevention of Accidents (RoSPA)
- Other government bodies as appropriate

The Empower School Ltd adheres to all guidelines in the production of Health & Safety documentation to ensure the safety of our course participants and staff. All staff are trained in the relevant areas they deliver, and we ensure staff are kept up to date with mandatory training for the safety of all.

Health and Safety Management System

The Management of Health and Safety at Work Regulations (Regulation 5) requires the employer to have arrangements in place to cover health and safety. These arrangements should, where possible, be integrated within the management system that is already in place for the business.

Risk Management Monitoring of Safety and Safety Checks

Safety is monitored in a variety of ways. On an informal level, all staff are required to monitor safety as they undertake their daily work. Various formal inspection regimes exist, which are designed to be appropriate to the subject. Sites are inspected in collaboration with Poltimore House staff. Critical issues are flagged directly so that more immediate action can be taken. Equipment is inspected in accordance with industry standards. Accident reports are monitored by the Director/Safeguarding Lead who will flag any potential issues with safety controls and investigate where necessary.

Risk Assessments

Risk assessments are treated as working 'live' documents that reflect the reality on the ground. They work within policy but also help to inform it. Staff are able to participate in the construction of risk assessments. Staff have a duty to read and understand risk assessments and be familiar with their contents. Risk assessments must work within policy.

All risk assessments are held electronically, and staff have a duty to ensure they have read and understood the relevant risk assessments and to ensure they read the document annually. An annual update and reminder will be provided to all staff that refers to risk assessments and health and safety management. If an activity is found not to have a risk assessment, it is the duty of staff to report this, and the Health & Safety Officer will advise upon this. Staff have a duty to report concerns they have relating to risk assessment, and this is encouraged as part of a positive feedback process to improve and review content. Our accident and incident procedures are in line with HSE guidelines and are reviewed annually along with all risk assessments. All risk assessments relating to H&S are reviewed and signed off by the Health & Safety Officer who is qualified to perform the task.

Health and Safety Policy and Procedure Overview

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Health & Safety matters are critical to the effective delivery of our work. All staff are responsible for the health and safety of participants and colleagues. Staff delivering courses/education need to be aware that others on site may not know or be aware of the risks present. In order to ensure that the safety of participants and staff is effectively managed, all staff need to consider the following:

- Being aware of and understanding the up-to-date risk assessment for the activity and the site risk assessment.
- If you are unsure about whether the activity is risk assessed, speak to your line manager.
- Being aware of and understanding any SOP for the activity.
- Ensure you are clear on the details of all The Empower School Ltd policies.
- Never carry out an activity for which you have no training or experience or that you are uncomfortable delivering.
- Undertake your own dynamic risk assessment as you work and be prepared to change plans with the weather or if changes in behaviour or needs increase risks.
- Report any accidents/incidents through the correct procedures.
- If you need a refresher on the delivery of activities, ask the team. You are the only one who will know whether you feel comfortable delivering an activity/session.
- Any abuse, bullying or other incident must be recorded following The Empower School Ltd policies.

Hygiene Facilities

School site must have access to hand washing water. This is provided by access to main toilet facilities on site. Soap and antibacterial gel must be available. The locations of these facilities must be such that they promote hand washing at appropriate times, such as at toilets, entrances, and areas where food is prepared and eaten.

Induction

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Health and Safety information is a key part of the induction process and is included on the induction checklist. Staff are required to sign to say they have read and understood the Health and Safety Policy and procedures for The Empower School Ltd.

Fire and Emergency

All staff will be briefed on the contents of this plan at induction and on an annual basis. This will be augmented by fire drills which will be undertaken termly. Evacuation procedures are also made known to all contractors/visitors.

Evacuation Procedures

The evacuation procedure for each location is displayed and all staff and visitors must ensure that they are familiar with this. This information is also available to staff electronically.

Manual Handling

Manual handling injuries can occur wherever people are at work. Manual labour, awkward postures, manual materials handling and previous or existing injury are all risk factors implicated in the development of manual handling injuries. Manual handling is defined as the supporting and transporting of a load by human effort and includes lifting, lowering, pushing, pulling, or carrying.

The Empower School Ltd will ensure that:

- Manual handling operations that present a risk of injury are identified in risk assessments.
- Handling operations which present a risk of injury are avoided, so far as is reasonably practicable, by eliminating the need for the load to be moved or by the introduction of automation or mechanisation.
- Those operations that cannot be avoided are assessed using an ergonomic approach that considers the Task, Individual Capacity, Load and Environment (TILE) elements to determine the level of risk.
- Measures required to eliminate the risk (or reduce it to the lowest level that is reasonably practicable) are identified from the information in the risk assessment.
- Any new work that might involve manual handling operations is considered.

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- Re-assessment is carried out immediately if any of the components of the work situation have changed. Incidents that result in musculoskeletal injury to assistants and volunteers are fully investigated and risk assessments and systems of work are reviewed in the light of such incidents.
- Staff recruited to posts involving manual handling are suitable for the work they are required to undertake.
- Job descriptions sent to applicants for employment include details of manual handling tasks where these are part of requirement of the post.
- Line Managers actively monitor the ability and health of their staff.
- Suitable information, training and supervision is provided for all staff engaged in manual handling tasks and that such training is recorded, monitored, evaluated, and reviewed.

All staff involved with manual handling activity should:

- Follow the company's risk assessment and should not deviate from this without good reason.
- Not undertake a manual handling activity when a reasonably practicable alternative exists.
- Use any mechanical aids that have been provided for their use and for which they have been trained.
- Immediately report any faults with mechanical aids.
- Assist and cooperate with the process of the assessment of risk.
- Report all accidents, injuries and near misses involving handling activities — however trivial.
- Inform their Line Manager if they are unable to undertake their normal manual handling duties because of injury, illness, or any other condition.
- Not undertake any manual handling operation that they believe is beyond their ability.

PPE

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Personal Protective Equipment (PPE) is to be supplied and used at work wherever there are risks to health and safety that cannot be adequately controlled in other ways. PPE will only be used as a last resort when preventative or other control measures cannot be applied. The Empower School Ltd will ensure that:

- Protective equipment is provided when the risk presented by a work activity cannot be adequately controlled by other means. All reasonable steps will be taken to secure the health and safety of staff, assistants, volunteers, and pupils who use PPE.
- Information and training are provided regarding the correct choice and use of PPE either via risk assessment or via formal or informal training.
- PPE is assessed for suitability.
- PPE that has been provided meets a statutory obligation and is maintained.
- All staff will:
 - Make full and proper use of all PPE that has been provided.
 - Inspect all PPE before use to ensure that it is suitable, clean, and undamaged. • Ensure that all PPE is sterilised when worn by multiple individuals.
 - Report any defective PPE to their Line Manager.
 - Report any discomfort or ill health experienced as a consequence of wearing the equipment.
 - Not undertake any activities or work unless the correct equipment is being provided.
 - Correctly store PPE and contact their Line Manager if they require storage.

Driving at Work

Driving for work includes driving a company vehicle or driving any vehicle when on company business. This includes travel between sites or any other company providing a service within the school. How people drive on their own commute and in their own vehicle is a private matter, but there is an expectation that the good practice of driving for work is adopted on a voluntary basis and that all legal requirements for driving are met at all times. If it is suspected that a member of staff

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is in violation of the law, regardless of whether this is during a commute or on company business, staff are duty bound to report this to Safeguarding Lead/Director.

The Empower School Ltd will ensure that:

- Consideration is made to the avoidance of driving or use of an alternative mode of travel, where these are reasonably practicable alternatives.
- A risk assessment is provided for driving at work and will communicate the necessary control measures to the relevant members of assistants and volunteers.

*Drivers are fit and competent to drive and they hold a valid driving licence. They are suitably insured for business use, are familiar with the vehicle and the task, understand the risk assessment findings and control measures, and have received appropriate training as necessary.

- Drivers of company vehicles are competent at undertaking vehicle checks.
- Company vehicles are appropriate for the task and maintained in a clean and roadworthy condition.

Staff who are driving for work must:

- Follow any advice, information, instruction, and training given by the company.
- Have a valid driver's licence for the class of vehicle they are driving.
- So far as is reasonably practicable, ensure that the vehicle is adequate for the purpose and is in a safe mechanical condition. This is particularly important for privately owned and driven vehicles.
- Comply with traffic legislation, be conscious of road safety and demonstrate safe driving. It is expected that any person driving vehicles on company business will not be under the influence of drink or drugs and must not drive whilst disqualified.
- Stop after a crash or similar incident with which they are involved. All relevant assistants and volunteers must provide a copy of their driving licence on request and declare any driving convictions.
- Inform the Safeguarding Lead/Director if they become aware of any medical condition or take medication that might affect their ability to drive.

Control of Substances Hazardous to Health (COSHH)

Using chemicals or other hazardous substances at work may put people's health at risk, thus the company is required to control exposure to hazardous substances to prevent ill health. The aim is to protect members of staff, pupils and others who may be exposed by complying with the Control of Substances Hazardous to Health Regulations (COSHH) as amended.

Hazardous substances include:

- Substances used directly in work activities (e.g., chemicals, paints, adhesives, cleaning agents) and substances generated during work activities.
- Naturally occurring substances (e.g., dust) and biological agents (e.g., bacteria and other microorganisms).

All staff have responsibilities under COSHH Regulations, and are expected to:

- Take part in training programmes.
- Observe container hazard symbols.
- Practice safe working with hazardous substances.
- Report any concerns immediately.
- Wear, correctly use and maintain any personal protective equipment provided.
- Return all hazardous substances to their secure location after use.
- Observe all control measures correctly.

Violence and Aggression

The Empower School Ltd recognises the difficulties in managing violence and aggression at work and aims to put in place steps to identify and minimise risks to support members of staff, assistants, and volunteers. The Empower School Ltd will monitor incidents to help address any potential problems.

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The Health and Safety Executive's definition of work-related violence is any incident in which a person is abused, threatened, or assaulted in circumstances relating to their work. All staff members, assistants, and volunteers whose job requires them to deal with the public can be at risk from violence.

The Empower School Ltd will:

- Consider risk from violence and aggression in consultation with staff and their representatives, where appropriate. Control measures and residual risk will be recorded in risk assessments.
- Provide instruction and training regarding violence at work to staff, assistants, and volunteers on induction and during other workplace training sessions as appropriate to the role.
- *Record all physical and verbal threats to assistants and volunteers.
- Classify all incidents in accordance with HSE's guidelines, using headings such as place, time, type of incident, potential severity, people involved and possible causes. The school will investigate all complaints which relate to violence at work.
- Report any violence and aggression to the police at the member of staff's/assistant's/volunteer's request.
- Establish monitoring arrangements and if a violent or aggressive incident occurs, risk assessments will be reviewed immediately to take into account the circumstances surrounding the incident to prevent or minimise the risk of a further occurrence.

All staff will:

- Attend appropriate training sessions if they are deemed to be at risk at work from violence or aggression.
- Report any incidents of violent or threatening behaviour to their Line Manager.
- Complete an incident report form after any violent incidents. This form outlines who has been involved, along with details of the situation that lead to the incident occurring.
- Cooperate with management arrangements for dealing with violence and aggression.

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Statement of General Policy Responsibility of Action Arrangements

- To prevent accidents and cases of work-related ill health and provide adequate control of health and safety risks arising from work activities.
- To provide adequate training to ensure employees are competent to do their work.
- To engage and consult with employees on day-to-day health and safety conditions and provide advice and supervision on occupational health.
- To maintain safe and healthy working conditions.

*To implement emergency procedures - evacuation in case of fire or another significant incident.

Health & Safety Law poster is displayed: On and around Poltimore site.

First-Aid box is located: At and around Poltimore site and in company vehicles. 